impressed. Paul Nitze recorded his impression of the second meeting of the 16 October as ‘sophomoric babble’.[41] Dean Acheson was exasperated by meetings that were ‘repetitive, leaderless, and a waste of time,’ and gave up attending them.[42] ExComm nevertheless provided the President with opportunities to engage with the arguments. There were also private meetings with senior officials and former officials. One of the more trusted wise persons was Robert Lovett, former Defense Secretary in Truman’s Pentagon, who supported the blockade and who spoke with Kennedy on 18 October (immediately after Gromyko had left the Oval Office).

To preserve the appearance of normality, Kennedy continued to campaign for Democratic candidates in the Congressional mid-term elections. On Friday, 19 October, he held his only meeting with the Joint Chiefs. It was a less than joyous occasion, inasmuch as the military made clear their unhappiness. General LeMay suggested that the blockade was worse than the appeasement at Munich and would lead to war. Appeasement had a particular resonance for Kennedy as his father, Joseph, had been Roosevelt’s ambassador in London and supported Neville Chamberlain’s policy. LeMay also addressed one of JFK’s greatest concerns: what would Khrushchev do in West Berlin if Kennedy moved on Cuba? LeMay was in no doubt that Khrushchev would do nothing. LeMay’s reasoning was that Khrushchev would do nothing because he knew how many of his cities SAC would burn: all of them.

After the meeting, the President left on the campaign trail. In his absence, ExComm was tasked with arguing through the cases for the air strike and the blockade. Robert Kennedy chaired the meeting. Bundy led the case for the air strike (even though at one point he felt it would be preferable to live with the missiles) and McNamara argued for the blockade. Robert Kennedy persuaded his brother to abandon campaigning and return to Washington from Chicago. The following day, Saturday, 20 October, the President chaired the meeting of the National Security Council that committed the administration to blockading Cuba and confronting the Soviet Union.

The blockade was designed as a first step. If it succeeded, there would be no need for the second. Preparations for air strikes and an invasion nevertheless proceeded apace. On the morning of Sunday, 21 October,